

Writing four-part harmony

Writing your own chorale harmony will help you judge your understanding of the subject. You can make your own melody or choose a famous one, but the melody should be in a regular 4/4 or 3/4, and in a fairly simple key signature.

Recommendations for writing a four-part harmony

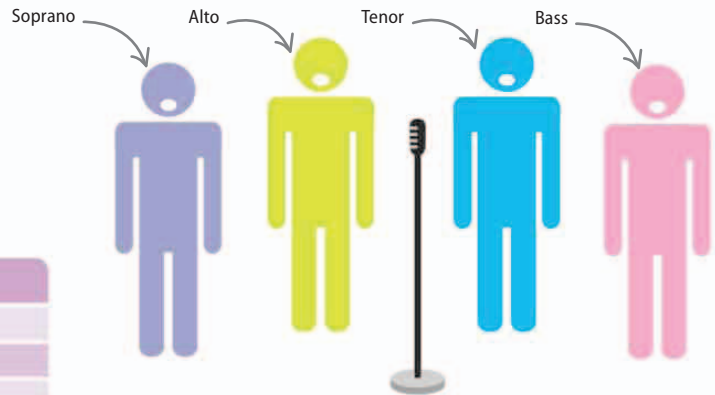
Avoid sequences of parallel octaves and fifths, which sound clumsy.

Stay within the range of each voice part.

Do not overload the harmony with complexity and interest if you want the melody line to be followed throughout.

Avoid crossing voices on the same chord.

Use stepwise motion as much as possible. Do not include an interval leap wider than an octave.



△ Vocal quartet

Much Baroque music often performed by choirs was originally written for one voice per part—a vocal quartet. In the 20th century, jazz, barbershop, and Gospel music revived the tradition of writing for vocal quartets.

△ "Now Thank We All Our God"

Here are the first two phrases of an old German chorale harmonized by Felix Mendelssohn. Note how he observes all the "rules" of harmonization in this example.

LOOKING CLOSER

Doubling voices

If you are using triadic harmony, it is likely that one note in every four-part chord will be a double of the other. Often the top and bottom notes will be doubles of each other, especially the first and last notes of a phrase, but it is important to make each part independent. Some guidelines are listed here.

In root position triads, double the root, except in diminished triads, double the third, otherwise the tritone interval is too prominent.

In V-vi of minor keys, double the third of the vi chord.

In first-inversion triads, double the root of the chord rather than the bass.

In second-inversion triads, double the bass.

Resolve a dominant seventh chord downward by a step.